Topic 11 — Marathas

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Maratha (मराठा) Empire | Shivaji (शिवाजी) | Administrative Structure of Shivaji | Peshwas | Peshwa (पेशवा) Period | Maratha Revenue System | Ashtapradhan (अष्टप्रधान) Council | Chauth (चौथ) | Sardeshmukhi (सरदेशमुखी) | Balaji Vishwanath (बालाजी विश्वनाथ) | Baji Rao I | Third Battle of Panipat (पानीपत)

Sources baked in: NCERT *Themes in Indian History Part II*, RS Sharma *Medieval India*, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025, Ghatnachakra Indian History (Sikh / Maratha / Later Mughal) **Weight:** ★★★ — Peshwa order (2023 Q35, 2024 Q1, 2025 Q149), Chauth, Deshmukh A/R, Panipat III 1761 **Last verified:** September 2026 — Shivaji early life expanded; Chauth/Sardeshmukhi teaching thickened; cryptic year-Q / "answer is B" lines scrubbed from teaching body **Current Affairs:** N/A (purely historical)

11.1 Maratha Empire — Phases

- The Maratha base was the **Western Ghats** (पश्चिमी घाट), Konkan, and Deccan hill-forts.
- **Shivaji** built **swaraj** (स्वराज) and took the title **Chhatrapati** in **1674**.
- After **1680**, **Sambhaji** fought Aurangzeb's Deccan war.
- **Rajaram** and **Tarabai** continued that resistance.
- **Sambhaji** was executed in **1689**.
- **Shahu** was released after Aurangzeb's death (**1707**) and won the succession (उत्तराधिकार क्रम) against Tarabai's line.
- From **1713** the **Peshwa** became hereditary and then the real ruler.
- The Chhatrapati turned ceremonial.
- Later power was a **confederacy**, not one tight kingdom.
- The **Peshwa** sat at **Pune**.
- **Scindia** sat at **Gwalior**.
- **Holkar** sat at **Indore**.
- **Gaekwad** sat at **Baroda**.
- **Bhonsle** sat at **Nagpur**.
- **Panipat III (1761)** broke the northern surge.
- Peshwa power ended with the British in **1818**.
- Maratha **chauth** reached the **Doab**, Bundelkhand, and Rohilkhand.
- That is the UP geography hook for this topic.

11.2 Shivaji

Shivaji Bhonsle | **1630–1680** | Born **Shivneri** | Mother **Jijabai** | Father **Shahji Bhonsle** | Coronation **Raigad, 1674**

Early life and rise (the past that papers assume)

- Shivaji was born at **Shivneri** fort (near Junnar (जुन्नर)) on **19 February 1630**. His mother was **Jijabai** and his father was **Shahji Bhonsle**, a Maratha noble in **Bijapur** (बीजापुर) service.
- **Shahji** held jagirs around **Pune, Supa, and Indapur**, and later served Bijapur in the Karnataka belt. Young Shivaji grew up mainly under **Jijabai** at Pune, not as a pampered court prince.
- The Pune estate was managed by **Dadaji Kondadev**, who trained Shivaji in revenue, local justice, and hill warfare with the **Mavali** peasantry of the Western Ghats.
- **Jijabai** shaped his sense of **Hindavi Swarajya (स्वराज्य)** — rule free of Bijapur–Mughal overlordship — through Ramayana (रामायण)–Mahabharata (महाभारत) ideals and hatred of local oppression.
- As a teenager he began taking hill forts. **Torna (1646)** was an early capture. **Rajgad** became a principal base. **Kondana** is the same fort later renamed **Sinhagad**.
- These early gains made him a threat to Bijapur's Deshmukh (देशमुख) network and to Mughal interest in the Deccan long before the coronation of **1674**.

Major military episodes

- **Afzal Khan** of Bijapur was killed at **Pratapgad in 1659**.
- Shivaji raided **Shaista Khan** in **Pune in 1663**, forcing the Mughal governor to leave the Deccan theatre humiliated.
- He sacked **Surat** (notably **1664**, and again later) to break Mughal trade (पण्याध्यक्ष) wealth on the western coast.
- He defeated Mughal forces at **Salher in 1672** — a rare open-field Maratha win in that phase.
- At the **1674** coronation on **Raigad**, **Pandit Vishweshwar (Gaga Bhatt)** of Banaras performed the rites and declared Shivaji a **Kshatriya**.
- Tradition remembers **Samarth Ramdas** as Shivaji's spiritual guide (**Dasbodh**; **Shivastuti**).

Afzal Khan episode (Pratapgad, 1659) — Cause, Course, Result

- **Cause:** Bijapur sent **Afzal Khan** with a large army to crush Shivaji after early Maratha gains on the Konkan and Ghats forts.
- **Course:** Shivaji met Afzal Khan at **Pratapgad** under a truce pretext. In close combat Shivaji killed Afzal Khan with **wagh nakh** (tiger claws), and his men routed the Bijapur force.
- **Result:** Bijapur prestige fell. Shivaji secured **Raigad** and expanded Swarajya in the western Deccan.

Shaista Khan and Surat — Cause, Course, Result

- **Cause:** After Bijapur failed, the Mughals under **Shaista Khan** occupied Pune and pressed Shivaji's homeland.
- **Course:** In **1663** Shivaji's night raid cut Shaista Khan's force inside Pune. In **1664** he sacked rich **Surat**.

- **Result:** Mughal prestige in the Deccan was shaken, and Aurangzeb turned to a heavier campaign under **Raja Jai Singh**.

Treaty of Purandar (1665) and Agra (1666) — Cause, Course, Result

- **Cause:** Aurangzeb sent **Raja Jai Singh I** to pin Shivaji after earlier Mughal failures.
- **Course:** Jai Singh besieged **Purandar**. Shivaji signed the **Treaty of Purandar**, surrendered **23 forts**, and accepted Mughal alliance terms; **Sambhaji** went as hostage for a time. In **1666** Shivaji was detained at **Agra** and later escaped.
- **Result:** Shivaji kept a core of forts, recovered strength in the hills, and moved toward full sovereignty instead of Bijapur jagirdari (इस्तमरारी) status.

Coronation, navy, opposition, death

- **Rajyabhishek** at **Raigad in 1674** made him **Chhatrapati**, not a Bijapur jagirdar.
- He built a **navy** to guard the Konkan. **Sindhudurg** and **Vijaydurg** are key naval forts from this phase.
- Big **Deshmukhs** opposed him because they wanted to remain **Bijapur feudal lords**, not subjects of an independent Maratha state.
- He died at **Raigad in 1680**. He did **not** fight at Panipat III (**1761**).

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Resistance from Deshmukhs (UPPCS 2024 Format):** - **Assertion (A):** Shivaji faced stubborn resistance from entrenched local Maratha hereditary chieftains and revenue lords (**Deshmukhs** like the Mores of Javli, Ghorpades of Mudhol, and Nimbalkars of Phaltan). *(True)* - **Reason (R):** These Deshmukhs preferred remaining autonomous feudal vassals under the Adil Shahi Sultanate of Bijapur, which guaranteed their hereditary estates and privileges, rather than submitting to a centralized Maratha Swarajya. *(True, and (R) is the correct explanation of (A)).*

11.3 Administrative Structure of Shivaji — Ashtapradhan

Identity: Council of **eight** ministers | Advises the **Chhatrapati** after **1674** | **Not** the same as countryside **Deshmukhs**

- Shivaji's **Ashtapradhan** was a council of **eight ministers**. In his lifetime the **Peshwa** was only **one of eight**, not the sovereign.
- Ministers were appointed on **loyalty and ability**, not as hereditary Deshmukh chiefs.

Minister	Also called	Portfolio
Peshwa	Mukhya Pradhan	General administration
Amatya	Majumdar	Finance and accounts
Mantri	Waqia Navis	Chronicle and private records
Senapati	Sar-i-Naubat	Army command

Minister	Also called	Portfolio
Sumant	Dabir	Foreign affairs
Nyayadhish	—	Chief justice
Panditrao	Pandit Rao	Religion, charity, ritual (कर्मकाण्ड)
Sachiv	Shuru Navis	Correspondence and seal (मुद्रा)

- From **1713** the Peshwa office became **hereditary** and gradually eclipsed the rest of the council.
- **Deshmukhs** were Bijapur-era feudal chiefs in the countryside. They are **not** the eight Ashtapradhan ministers.

11.4 Revenue — Chauth & Sardeshmukhi

Identity: Maratha fiscal tools of expansion | Money without always annexing land | Classic confused pair

Chauth

- **Chauth** means **one-fourth (25%)** of the assessed land revenue of a territory.
- It was taken as a **protection levy**: pay chauth and Maratha forces would spare the area from raid, or claim to shield it from other predators.
- It let the Marathas draw cash from **Mughal and other territories** without immediate full annexation.
- Under the early Peshwas, chauth from **Malwa**, **Gujarat**, and the **Doab–Bundelkhand** belt funded northern campaigns — the UP geography hook.

Sardeshmukhi

- **Sardeshmukhi** is an extra **10%** of land revenue.
- It was claimed as the hereditary due of the Maratha ruler as **supreme deshmukh (sardeshmukh)** of the Deccan countryside.
- It is **not** another name for chauth. Papers often plant sardeshmukhi as the wrong “protection quarter.”

How the two sit together

- Together, chauth and sardeshmukhi can reach about **35%** of land revenue where both were demanded.
- **Balaji Vishwanath** used diplomacy to get Mughal recognition of Maratha claims; the **Treaty of Lanavada (1718)** is the high-yield recognition moment for chauth rights.
- **Bajirao I** then expanded the same fiscal reach deeper into Malwa, Gujarat, and Bundelkhand.

Confused revenue names (do not swap)

Name	What it is	Trap
Chauth (चौथ)	**25%** protection levy	Calling it the hereditary 10%
Sardeshmukhi (सरदेशमुखी)	Extra **10%** sardeshmukh claim	Calling it the protection quarter
Abwab (अबवाब)	Miscellaneous extra cesses	Treating it as Maratha protection revenue
Jamadani	A **textile**	Using it as a revenue term
Rakhi (राखी)	Local protection arrangement with chiefs (e.g. Bundelkhand belts)	Equating it with chauth's 25% name
Saranzami (सरंजामी)	Land supporting Maratha **jagirdars'** livelihood	Mixing it with chauth

> **Logic:** Asked "Maratha protection revenue / one-fourth" → **Chauth**. Asked "extra hereditary deshmukh share" → **Sardeshmukhi**.

11.5 Peshwas

Peshwa | Prime minister under Shahu | Hereditary de facto ruler from **Balaji Vishwanath (1713)**

Peshwa	Years	Fact
Balaji Vishwanath	1713–1720	First hereditary; **Lanavada 1718**
Bajirao I (Rau)	1720–1740	North expansion; **Palkhed 1728** vs Nizam
Balaji Bajirao (Nana Saheb)	1740–1761	Panipat III generation
Madhav Rao I	1761–1772	Post-1761 recovery
Narayan Rao	1772–1773	Murdered
Raghunath Rao (Raghoba)	1773–1774	After Narayan; Anglo-Maratha (आंग्ल-मराठा) bridge
Baji Rao II	1795–1818	Last Peshwa

- **Balaji Vishwanath** settled the Shahu–Tarabai split and made the Peshwa office hereditary and durable.
- At **Aurangzeb's death (1707)**, Maratha leadership against the Mughals was in **Tarabai's** hands.
- By the **Treaty / agreement of Sangola (1750)** under **Balaji Bajirao**, the Chhatrapati became a ceremonial figure and the **Peshwa** the real head of the confederacy.
- **Saranzami** land grants supported the livelihood of Maratha jagirdars.
- **Modi script** was used in Maratha administrative and revenue documents.

- **Ahilyabai** of the **Holkar** house ruled from **Indore**.
- **Treaty of Lanavada (1718)** won Mughal recognition of Maratha chauth rights.
- **Bajirao I** drove into **Malwa**, **Gujarat**, and **Bundelkhand**. **Palkhed (1728)** is his famous campaign against the **Nizam**.
- **Mastani** was Bajirao I's companion from the Bundelkhand world linked to **Chhatrasal**. Their son **Shamsher Bahadur** later held a Bundelkhand line; orthodox Pune circles opposed the relationship.
- **Balaji Bajirao** is **not** the same person as **Bajirao I**.
- On chronology lists, read the **four (चातुर्याम) names** carefully: some lists use **Madhav Rao I** before **Narayan Rao**; other lists skip Madhav and place **Raghoba** after Narayan.

> **Logic:** Bajirao I = north surge **1720–40**. Balaji Bajirao = Nana Saheb of the Panipat generation. Madhav recovers after **1761**; Narayan follows Madhav.

11.6 Third Battle of Panipat (14 January 1761)

Date:14 January 1761 | Abdali (अब्दाली) vs **Marathas** under **Sadashiv Rao Bhau**

- **Cause:** After the Maratha northern surge into the **Punjab and Doab**, **Ahmad Shah Abdali (Durrani)** returned to India to block Maratha dominance and protect his Afghan sphere. An immediate spark was Maratha expulsion of his viceroy **Timur Shah** from **Lahore**. Rohilla chief **Najib-ud-Daula (Najib Khan)** allied with Abdali; Abdali had earlier (1757) left him as Mir Bakshi/agent at Delhi.
- **Course:** The battle was fought at **Panipat on 14 January 1761**. Maratha commander **Sadashiv Rao Bhau** led the army; Peshwa heir **Vishwas Rao** was killed on the field. **Bajirao I** had died in **1740** and did not command here. Eyewitness historian **Kashiraj Pandit** recorded the disaster.
- **Result:** Abdali won decisively. The defeat ended the Maratha **all-India northern surge** but did **not** erase the confederacy overnight. **Balaji Bajirao** died the same year; **Madhav Rao I** later recovered some ground.

> **Logic:** Panipat I (**1526**) = Babur (बाबर). Panipat II (**1556**) = Akbar (अकबर)–Hemu. Panipat III (**1761**) = Abdali–Marathas. **Nadir Shah (1739)** is a separate Afghan shock.

11.7 Master Fact-Locks — Maratha Polity, Ashtapradhan, Peshwaship & Panipat III

Domain / Concept	Canonical Historical Specifics & Facts	Official Exam Focus
Shivaji's Birth, Coronation & Capital	• Born at the hill fort of **Shivneri** in **1627 CE** (or 1630 CE); died in **1680 CE** at age 53. • Crowned as ***Chhatrapati*** at **Raigad Fort** in **June 1674 CE** by the renowned Banaras theologian **Pandit Vishweshwar (Gaga Bhatt)**, who formally invested him with the sacred thread and proclaimed him a Kshatriya of the Sisodia Rajput lineage. • Made **Raigad** his imperial capital. • **Early Military Sequence:** Fort of Chakan (1648) \rightarrow First clash with Mughals (1657) \rightarrow Slaying of Bijapuri general Afzal Khan with tiger claws (*bagh nakh*) at Pratapgad (1659) \rightarrow Night raid on Shaista Khan at Pune (1663) \rightarrow First sack of Surat (1664) \rightarrow Battle of Salher (1672, decisive Maratha victory over imperial Mughal field army).	Genesis of Maratha Swarajya
Purandar & Agra Escape	• **Treaty of Purandar (June 1665 CE):** Signed between Shivaji and Mughal general **Raja Jai Singh I of Amber**; Shivaji surrendered 23 out of 35 forts (yielding 4 lakh huns revenue), retaining 12 forts (1 lakh huns). • **Agra Captivity (1666 CE):** Imprisoned in **Jaipur Bhawan at Agra** by Aurangzeb; made a dramatic escape inside large fruit and sweet baskets on 17 August 1666.	Diplomatic & strategic landmarks
Ashtapradhan Council of Eight Ministers	Not a cabinet with collective responsibility, but eight departmental heads acting as personal advisors/secretaries to Shivaji (the Chhatrapati could accept or reject any advice): 1. **Peshwa (Mukhya Pradhan):** Prime Minister; general administration, royal welfare. 2. **Amatya (Majumdar):** Finance and Revenue Minister; audited imperial receipts and accounts. 3. **Waqianavis (Mantri):** Interior Minister; intelligence, espionage, court daily proceedings. 4. **Sachiv (Surnavis / Shuru-Nawis):** In-charge of royal correspondence, checked draft firmans. 5. **Sumant (Dabir):** Foreign Minister; diplomatic relations, foreign envoys. 6. **Senapati (Sar-i-Naubat):** Commander-in-Chief; military recruitment, organization, food supply. 7. **Pandit Rao (Danadhyaksha):** High Priest; religious grants, moral conduct, social disputes. 8. **Nyayadhish:** Chief Justice; judicial civil and criminal administration according to Hindu Shastras. *(Note: All ministers except Pandit Rao and Nyayadhish were required to command troops in the field).*	Complete 8-portfolio administrative lock

Domain / Concept	Canonical Historical Specifics & Facts	Official Exam Focus
Currency & Maritime Systems	• Silver coins: **Rupaya**, **Lari** (fish-hook shaped silver wire coin from Persian Gulf / Bijapuri coast), and **Taka**. • **Ruka:** Bronze / copper coin of the South Indian **Kakatiya dynasty**, NOT a Maratha silver coin.	Numismatic distinctions
Saranzami Land Revenue System	Specialized Maratha land assignment system where villages/lands were granted as **Saranzam** to Maratha military commanders (*Saranjamdars* / Jagirdars) for their personal maintenance and the upkeep of their military contingents.	Agrarian military tenure
Chauth & Sardeshmukhi	• **Chauth:** Assessment of **one-fourth (25%)** of standard land revenue levied on non-Maratha territories (*Mughalai*) as protection money against Maratha raids. • **Sardeshmukhi:** Additional levy of **one-tenth (10%)** claimed by Shivaji in his hereditary capacity as supreme head (*Sardeshmukh*) of Maharashtra.	Dual revenue extraction spine
Succession & Regents (1680–1708)	• **Sambhaji (1680–1689):** Eldest son of Shivaji; captured and brutally executed by Aurangzeb at Tulapur. • **Rajaram (1689–1700):** Second son; took refuge at Jinji during Mughal siege; operated as regent for young Shahu. • **Tarabai (1700–1707+):** Widow of Rajaram; crowned her 4-year-old son **Shivaji II**; led fierce Maratha resistance against Aurangzeb, recapturing Sinhagad, Raigad, and Satara. At Aurangzeb's death (1707), Maratha leadership was entirely in her hands. • **Chhatrapati Shahu (1708–1749):** Released by Prince Azam Shah; defeated Tarabai at the **Battle of Khed (1707 CE)**; crowned at Satara.	Royal house evolution
Peshwa Ascendancy & Sangola Agreement	1. **Balaji Vishwanath (1713–1720):** Appointed Peshwa in November 1713 by Shahu; negotiated 1719 treaty with Sayyid brothers (the *"Magna Carta of Maratha Dominion"*). 2. **Bajirao I (1720–1740):** Undefeated cavalry genius; preached northern expansion (*"Strike at the trunk of the decaying tree"*); defeated Nizam at Palkhed (1728), established Maratha confederacy. 3. **Balaji Bajirao / Nana Saheb (1740–1761):** Post of Peshwa became hereditary; capital shifted to Pune. • **Treaty of Sangola (1750 CE):** Chhatrapati Ramraja became a ceremonial titular figurehead (*"Mayor of the Palace"*), and the Peshwa emerged as the de facto sovereign head of the Maratha Confederacy. 4. **Madhavrao I (1761–1772):** Restored Maratha prestige in the North after Panipat; placed Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II back on the Delhi throne in 1772. 5. **Narayanrao (1772–1773):** Murdered in a palace conspiracy orchestrated by his ambitious uncle **Raghunathrao (Raghoba)**.	Hereditary Peshwaship sequence

Domain / Concept	Canonical Historical Specifics & Facts	Official Exam Focus
Third Battle of Panipat (14 January 1761)	• **Combatants:** Maratha army under **Sadashivrao Bhau** (accompanied by young Vishwasrao) vs. Afghan invader **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Durrani) allied with Rohilla chief **Najib-ud-Daulah (Najib Khan)** and Nawab Shuja-ud-Daula of Awadh. • **Immediate Cause:** Ahmad Shah Abdali sought vengeance against Marathas for expelling his viceroy **Timur Shah** from Lahore in 1758. • **Eyewitness Account:** Chronicler **Kashiraj Pandit** was an eyewitness: *"The Third Battle of Panipat proved catastrophic for the Marathas."* • **Merchant's Encrypted Message:** *"Two pearls have been dissolved [Bhau and Vishwasrao], 22 gold coins have been lost [prominent sardars], and of the silver and copper the total cannot be cast up."*	Decisive 18th-century battle
Modi Script	Cursive script developed in Maharashtra; utilized across all official Maratha administrative, judicial, and revenue documents.	Marathi administrative script